

81.1 War in Italy

The nasty, complicated, bloody war that followed saw multiple switchings of sides, including that of the English mercenary John Hawkwood, who fought in turn for Florence, Milan, and Gregory XI; he was in the pope's pay, though, when he led his men in a sack of the Italian city of Faenza that ended in massacre of the civilians, rape of every woman under the age of sixty, and wholesale looting. A Sienese chronicle says that Hawkwood himself killed at least one young woman, and that a priest with the expedition stood at the gates of Faenza, calling out to the rape victims to submit because "this is good for the army." A year later, a similar scene unfolded at Cesena, where the pope's legate Robert of Geneva led an attack in which at least four thousand unarmed citizens were killed: "women, old and young, and sick, and children, and pregnant women, were cut to pieces at the point of a dagger." Robert himself was heard to shout out, during the attack, "I will have more blood! kill all!—blood, blood!"[7]

By 1377, both Gregory XI and the antipapal league were sickened by the war, ready to negotiate a peace. On August 21, they agreed to a cease-fire; Gregory XI was still in the middle of messy negotiations with Florence on the